St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Your teacher has put two paragraphs on the board. One argues that technology has made people lazier (Paragraph A). The other argues that technology has not made us lazier (Paragraph B). Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Can anyone seriously deny that technology has made us lazier? Not only teenagers waste entire afternoons watching videos, but they also order every meal through delivery apps who bring food to their door within minutes. Apps, which are designed to help with homework, are frequently used for gaming instead. Students which live within walking distance still take the bus because moving feels like an unnecessary burden. The important of physical activity is something that our generation has completely forgotten. Only when someone hides their phone they can remember what life used to be like.

Has technology truly destroyed our work ethic, or are we simply judging a new generation by outdated beliefs? Many adults, which grew up without smartphones, accuse young people of laziness simply because their work happens on a screen. Never parents admit that teenagers today run online businesses and solve problems that older generations could not. What they fail to see is the significant of these new skills for the modern workplace. They also miss the possible that young people can be productive while holding a phone. In fact, technology has merely challenged the believe that hard work must always look physical.

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Young people forget social skills because they text too much.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the overuse of texting …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers struggle to focus because notifications interrupt them constantly.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the constant interruptions …'.*

Example 2: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	Some blame phones for tiredness, but late-night gaming is the real cause.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While some blame phones for tiredness …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People say teenagers are antisocial, but they themselves avoid family dinners.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people say teenagers are antisocial …'.*

Example 3: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Class question 1 (Easy): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Schools should teach students how to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Teenagers need a safe space to practise speaking in groups.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What teenagers need …'.*

Example 4: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Class question 1 (Easy): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one supportive friend to feel understood.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to feel brave for a moment to speak to a stranger.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence as a cleft sentence. The sentences are about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. Sets 1–4 are straightforward; sets 5–8 require you to change the part of speech.

Example Set 1 (It-cleft – the cause)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the fear of real conversations …'.*

Example Set 2 (Wh-cleft – what is needed)

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What students need to do …'.*

Example Set 3 (It-cleft – the contrast)

Simple sentence:	People blame social media, but modern phones are the real problem.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people blame social media …'.*

Example Set 4 (All-cleft – the only thing needed)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one proper conversation to understand the value of talking.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Example Set 5 (It-cleft – the cause, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People feel brave when they insult others online because they are anonymous.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the anonymity …'.*

Example Set 6 (It-cleft – the contrast, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.

Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people think technology is convenient …'.*

Example Set 7 (Wh-cleft – the recommendation, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Schools should make students aware that talking face to face is important.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*

Example Set 8 (All-cleft – the only thing needed, word-form change)

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident for one minute to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …